A Catalogue of Spirits, Demons, and Household Superstitions

Book 1: Of Hearth, Threshold, and the Uninvited Dead
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Preface: Concerning Those Who Dwell Beside Us

There are three kinds of men who claim to understand spirits. The first are priests, who insist that every spirit may be appeased through proper ceremony. The second are scholars, who insist that every spirit may be explained through reason. The third are drunkards, who insist that every spirit they have encountered was exceptionally beautiful. Of these three, I have found the drunkards to be the most sincere. During my forty-seven years of travel throughout the provinces of Tianxia, I have personally investigated no fewer than three hundred and eleven reports of supernatural encounters. Of these, one hundred and nineteen were deliberate frauds, sixty-four were misunderstandings, twenty-three were attributable to spoiled wine, and nine were the inventions of particularly imaginative children. The remainder I have yet to explain. This book concerns those matters which ordinary men encounter in their daily lives: the scratching beneath the floorboards, the whispering beyond the bedroom curtain, the footsteps in an empty courtyard, and the familiar voice calling from a place where no living person stands. I make no claim that all such occurrences are the work of spirits. Indeed, my purpose is to warn the reader against believing too readily. However, I would also advise against answering when one's deceased mother calls from the well.

A Note to the Reader

It is customary to divide supernatural beings into three broad categories:

- Spirits (靈, Líng): Beings associated with places, objects, natural forces, or the lingering will of the deceased.
- Ghosts (鬼, Guǐ): The surviving remnants of souls, particularly those unable or unwilling to depart the mortal world.
- Demons (妖, Yāo): Entities whose nature has been altered by unnatural cultivation, spiritual corruption, or forces beyond ordinary comprehension.

These distinctions are useful but imperfect. A ghost may become a demon, a spirit may once have been human, and certain magistrates appear to possess the qualities of all three. I shall leave the classification of magistrates to a later volume.

Chapter I: Spirits of the Household

Entry I — The Ash Grandmother (灰婆, Huī Pó)

Classification: Benevolent Household Spirit

Disposition: Generally harmless, occasionally spiteful

Common Habitat: Fireplaces, stoves, kitchen hearths

It is said that when the eldest woman of a household dies after a lifetime of tending the family hearth, a fragment of her spirit may remain among the ashes. Such a spirit is called the Ash Grandmother. She seldom reveals herself, preferring to manifest through small domestic occurrences. Rice left upon the stove may remain warm long after the fire has been extinguished. A sleeping child may awaken to find an extra blanket tucked around their shoulders. Sometimes, those cooking alone will hear the quiet humming of an elderly woman. Such manifestations are considered blessings. However, the Ash Grandmother has a particular dislike for quarrelsome descendants. Families who regularly argue beside the hearth report that their cooking fires refuse to ignite, their soups turn bitter, and their kettles whistle even when empty.

Customary Appeasement:

On the first evening of winter, the eldest member of the household should place three grains of uncooked rice among the embers and say:

"Grandmother, the house remains warm. Rest without worry."

If the fire briefly burns blue, the offering has been accepted.

Recorded Incident:

In Willowford Village, a young widow reported that her fireplace continued burning despite the absence of wood. When questioned, she confessed that she had concealed her late mother-in-law's ashes beneath the hearth rather than burying them, fearing that the funeral would attract creditors. Upon the ashes receiving a proper burial, the disturbances ceased. The widow's creditors arrived the following morning.

Entry II — The Doorway Listener (門聽鬼, Mén Tīng Guǐ)

Classification: Lesser Wandering Ghost

Disposition: Curious; dangerous when acknowledged

Common Habitat: Doorways, thresholds, narrow corridors

The Doorway Listener is said to stand on the opposite side of a closed door, waiting for someone within to speak its name. No two witnesses agree upon its appearance, for few have seen the creature directly. Its presence is instead marked by three occurrences. First, conversation within the room becomes strangely quiet, as though the walls have grown thicker. Second, a faint breathing may be heard beneath the door. Third, someone outside will knock three times. It is believed that the Doorway Listener cannot cross a properly maintained threshold unless invited. It therefore imitates voices belonging to members of the household.

Traditional Warning:

A knock after midnight should never be answered by asking, “Who is there?” Instead, one should ask: “What business brings you beneath my roof?”
A human visitor will answer. A Doorway Listener will remain silent, for it possesses no business of its own.

Scholar's Observation:

I investigated seventeen alleged encounters. In eleven cases, the knocking was caused by shifting timber. In three, it was caused by mischievous servants.
In two, no explanation was discovered. In the final case, the household possessed no doors. I departed before sunset.

Entry III — The Rice-Bowl Child (碗童, Wǎn Tóng)

Classification: Minor Domestic Spirit

Disposition: Mischievous

Common Habitat: Pantries, dining rooms, storehouses

The Rice-Bowl Child is a small and troublesome creature believed to inhabit households where food is regularly wasted. Witnesses describe a child no taller than a wine jar, dressed in oversized garments and possessing an appetite out of proportion to its size. Its favorite amusement is stealing the final mouthful from an unattended bowl. More severe manifestations include spoiling stored grain, tangling cooking utensils, and hiding chopsticks from their proper pairs. It is particularly fond of wealthy households whose masters complain about the quality of their meals. Curiously, it seldom troubles poor families.

Household Custom:

An empty bowl should never be left upside down overnight. According to village belief, doing so invites the Rice-Bowl Child to overturn one's fortune. Those wishing to drive the spirit away should leave a bowl containing seven grains of rice outside the kitchen. The spirit will count the grains until dawn, at which point it must return to its hiding place.

Recorded Incident:

A magistrate in the eastern provinces ordered his servants to capture a Rice-Bowl Child after discovering that his prized ceremonial chopsticks disappeared each evening. The servants searched the estate for six days. The chopsticks were eventually discovered beneath the magistrate's bed, where his youngest daughter had hidden them. When asked why, she replied that she disliked watching her father beat servants for setting the table incorrectly. I consider this among the more satisfactory conclusions to a supernatural investigation.

Chapter II: Spirits of Water and Reflection

Entry IV — The Well Bride (井中娘, Jǐng Zhōng Niáng)

Classification: Water-Bound Ghost

Disposition: Sorrowful; potentially malevolent

Common Habitat: Abandoned wells, deep cisterns, flooded courtyards

Among the southern provinces, there exists a persistent belief concerning women who die before their wedding ceremonies. It is said that a bride whose marriage was prevented by betrayal, cruelty, or sudden death may linger within the nearest body of still water. Such spirits are called Well Brides. At night, a Well Bride may appear reflected in the water, standing behind the observer even when no person occupies that space. Witnesses frequently describe hearing the sound of wedding bells beneath the water. The spirit does not ordinarily attack. Instead, she asks a question:

"Has my husband arrived?"

There are numerous contradictory accounts regarding the proper response. Some villages advise silence. Others recommend telling the ghost that her husband died many years ago. In the province of Liang, it is customary to answer:

"The road is long, but the guests have not forgotten you."

This allegedly comforts the spirit sufficiently to permit escape.

A More Troubling Account

In the village of Qingshui, seven men drowned in the same well over the course of fourteen years. Each had recently married. The villagers believed a Well Bride had grown jealous of living wives. However, examination of the well revealed a narrow underground passage connected to an abandoned drainage chamber. Within were discovered several personal belongings, a rusted ceremonial knife, and the remains of a woman dressed in bridal silk. No evidence was found explaining the deaths of the seven men. I ordered the well sealed. Three months later, the village reported that its water had turned sweet.

Entry V — The Basin Watcher (盆影, Pén Yǐng)

Classification: Reflective Apparition

Disposition: Unknown

Common Habitat: Washbasins, bathing tubs, polished bronze mirrors

The Basin Watcher is most commonly encountered by individuals bathing alone after sunset. Unlike the Well Bride, it possesses no known human origin. Its manifestation begins with a reflection that fails to match the movements of the observer. The reflected face may smile when the observer does not. An arm may move beneath the water despite the observer remaining motionless. On rare occasions, witnesses claim to have seen their reflection turn away and walk beyond the edge of the basin.

Common Superstition:

Bathwater should be emptied before sleeping. Water left beneath moonlight is believed to retain the impressions of those who have gazed into it. A basin holding such impressions for seven consecutive nights may eventually acquire a reflection of its own.

Scholar's Observation:

My assistants and I conducted an experiment involving twelve polished basins filled with water and arranged beneath the moon. We observed no supernatural occurrence. However, one assistant refused to continue after claiming that his reflection had closed its eyes independently. Upon examination, I discovered he had been awake for nearly three days. I dismissed him to sleep. The following morning, his basin was empty. The other eleven remained full.

Entry VI — The Drowned Caller (溺呼鬼, Nì Hū Guǐ)

Classification: Restless Drowning Ghost

Disposition: Variable; frequently misunderstood

Common Habitat: Rivers, irrigation canals, floodplains

The Drowned Caller is believed to be the restless soul of one who perished beneath moving water. Unlike spirits bound to wells or ponds, these ghosts are said to travel along rivers. Their presence is most often reported during flood season. Fishermen speak of hearing voices among the reeds, sometimes calling for help and sometimes begging passersby to enter the water. One popular belief holds that a Drowned Caller can only depart the mortal world when another person drowns in its place. This belief has caused much unnecessary cruelty. I have personally witnessed villagers refuse to rescue drowning strangers for fear of exchanging places with a ghost. Let it therefore be clearly stated:

A drowning man should be rescued because he is drowning, regardless of whether he is alive, dead, or something in between.

Indeed, I have found that ropes are more effective than prayers in the majority of such circumstances.

Recorded Incident:

In the western valleys, I examined reports of a ghost appearing beside a river each seventh night. Upon inquiry, I discovered that a local ferryman had been using a white burial shroud to frighten competing boatmen from a profitable crossing. When confronted, he confessed. Two weeks after his arrest, the apparition was seen again. The ferryman remained imprisoned at the time. I have not yet returned to investigate.

Chapter III: Spirits of Roads, Forests, and Forgotten Places

Entry VII — The Lantern Borrower (借燈客, Jiè Dēng Kè)

Classification: Wandering Spirit

Disposition: Neutral unless deceived

Common Habitat: Mountain passes, ancient roads, abandoned bridges

Travelers walking alone at night occasionally encounter an elderly man carrying an extinguished lantern. He speaks politely and requests permission to borrow a flame. Those who provide him with fire are said to receive safe passage through dangerous terrain. Those who refuse may discover that every road leads them back to the same crossroads. It is important to distinguish the Lantern Borrower from an ordinary traveler. The spirit's lantern is traditionally described as having no wick. Furthermore, its shadow is always cast toward the light rather than away from it.

Customary Offering:

One should light the stranger's lantern without asking his destination. If he asks for directions, the appropriate response is:

"The road knows its travelers better than I."

Under no circumstances should the stranger be invited to accompany the traveler home.

Recorded Incident:

A merchant named Gao claimed to have assisted a Lantern Borrower while crossing the mountains north of Yushan. The following morning, he discovered that the path he had taken no longer existed. His companions accused him of drunkenness. Gao insisted he had consumed only tea. Having subsequently tasted the tea sold by the establishment where he lodged, I remain unconvinced.

Entry VIII — The Weeping Cypress (哭柏, Kū Bǎi)

Classification: Tree Spirit

Disposition: Protective or hostile according to treatment

Common Habitat: Ancient burial grounds, temple gardens, ancestral estates

The Weeping Cypress is believed to arise when the roots of an ancient tree intertwine with the remains of the dead. Such a tree develops an awareness of the suffering and memories buried beneath it. At night, its branches may produce sounds resembling human sobbing. Those who sleep beneath a Weeping Cypress sometimes experience dreams containing fragments of memories belonging to deceased strangers. Most such dreams are inconsequential. Some, however, have allegedly revealed forgotten burial sites, lost family heirlooms, or the names of murderers.

Traditional Prohibition:

One should never cut a Weeping Cypress without first presenting an apology to the dead buried beneath it. A red thread tied around its trunk is said to restrain its resentment.

Scholar's Observation:

In my travels, I encountered a cypress beneath which villagers claimed their ancestors gathered during the winter solstice. When I placed my palm against the trunk, I heard what appeared to be a woman's voice whispering a name. I recorded the name as accurately as possible. It was later identified as belonging to a village magistrate who had disappeared sixty-two years earlier. His remains were discovered beneath the roots. Whether this was a supernatural revelation or an extraordinary coincidence, I cannot say. I will admit that I have since become reluctant to sleep beneath trees.

Entry IX — The Fox Who Counts Names (數名狐, Shù Míng Hú)

Classification: Cultivated Animal Spirit

Disposition: Intelligent; unpredictable

Common Habitat: Forest shrines, abandoned academies, secluded gardens

There are many accounts of fox spirits acquiring human form through prolonged cultivation. Most are embellished beyond usefulness. However, one particularly consistent tradition concerns a white fox that collects human names. The creature is said to appear beside lonely roads in the form of a courteous scholar. It asks travelers three questions:

- Their family name.
- Their given name.
- The name by which their mother called them in childhood.

Those who answer all three questions are believed to surrender a portion of their fate to the fox. Thereafter, the creature may appear in their dreams or speak with their voice.

Traditional Advice

One should never provide a stranger with all three names. If pressed, a traveler may offer a false childhood name. The fox will supposedly recognize the deception but respect the cleverness.

Recorded Incident

A provincial examination candidate claimed that a white-haired scholar had stolen his name. For seven days afterward, every official document bearing his signature became illegible. When I questioned him, he admitted that he had failed the imperial examinations four consecutive times. I suggested that the examination officials might simply have difficulty reading his handwriting. He found this explanation deeply offensive.

Chapter IV: Superstitions of the Living

It would be impossible to catalogue every strange belief held by the people of Tianxia. Nevertheless, the following customs are sufficiently widespread to deserve preservation.

Custom	Common Belief
Never whistle after midnight.	Whistling invites wandering ghosts to follow the sound home.
Never place chopsticks upright in a bowl of rice.	This resembles funerary incense and invites the hungry dead to dine.
Never sweep the floor on the first morning of the new year.	Doing so sweeps away the household's accumulated fortune.
Never call a person's full name beside a river at night.	Water spirits may learn the name and imitate the speaker's voice.
Never sleep with a mirror facing the bed.	The reflection may awaken before its owner.
Never count the steps of a staircase in darkness.	A spirit may add an extra step that was not there before.
Never open an umbrella indoors after sunset.	Spirits sheltering within the fabric may be released.
Never leave a single shoe outside the bedroom door.	A wandering ghost may mistake it for an invitation.
Never praise an infant's beauty excessively.	Jealous spirits may attempt to exchange the child for one of their own.
Never burn a letter without reading it.	Unspoken words may return as restless whispers.
Never accept a coin found upon a grave.	It may be payment intended for a spirit's passage.
Never answer a voice calling your name three times from behind you.	The third summons may not come from the living.

Concerning Superstition and Reason

A farmer who refuses to whistle at midnight loses nothing but an opportunity to annoy his neighbors. A mother who removes a mirror from her child's bedroom loses nothing but a piece of furniture. However, a village that condemns an innocent woman because her reflection appeared strange has committed a crime far greater than any attributed to ghosts. Superstitions are harmless until men begin to mistake fear for knowledge. In this regard, I have observed that the living require considerably greater supervision than the dead.

Chapter V: Of False Exorcists and Convenient Demons

There exists throughout Tianxia a profitable trade in the removal of spirits. Certain practitioners possess genuine knowledge of ritual, talismans, and the cultivation of protective Qi. Others possess little beyond theatrical talent and an understanding of human desperation. I have encountered exorcists who sell blessed water drawn from ordinary wells, talismans inscribed with nonsensical characters, and protective incense manufactured from sawdust. One man charged a family thirty silver taels to remove a demon from their kitchen. The demon proved to be a particularly large rat. The man nevertheless demanded his payment, explaining that the creature had chosen the form of a rat to conceal its true nature.

I recommended that the family purchase a cat.

Five Signs of a Fraudulent Exorcist:

1. He claims that every ailment is caused by a different spirit.
2. He demands payment before examining the afflicted person.
3. He insists that only increasingly expensive ceremonies can avert disaster.
4. He forbids the household from seeking advice from physicians or other practitioners.
5. He claims that questioning his authority will anger the gods.

None of these signs alone proves dishonesty. Together, however, they are cause for considerable suspicion.

The Incident of the Seven Sealed Jars

In a village west of the capital, an itinerant exorcist convinced seven families that demons resided beneath their floors. He sold each family a sealed ceramic jar containing what he described as a captured spirit. He instructed the villagers never to open the jars, warning that doing so would release the demons. After the exorcist departed, a curious child broke one of the vessels. Inside were dried beans. The remaining jars contained dried beans as well. The villagers pursued the exorcist and brought him before the magistrate. During the hearing, the accused maintained that the demons had transformed themselves into beans to avoid detection. The magistrate, a man of uncommon patience, asked whether the demons could be cooked. The accused replied that they could not. The magistrate ordered the beans boiled. They made an excellent soup.

Chapter VI: On the Proper Conduct When Encountering the Unnatural

I have been asked repeatedly what a reasonable person ought to do upon encountering a spirit. My recommendations are as follows:

- First: Establish whether the apparition is truly supernatural.
- A white figure in a graveyard may be a ghost, a mourner, or laundry left hanging in an unfortunate position.
- Second: Avoid unnecessary confrontation.
- Many spirits appear to resent being disturbed. I have discovered that this characteristic is shared by most scholars.
- Third: Never offer a promise that cannot be fulfilled.
- Stories concerning ghosts frequently involve broken vows, neglected obligations, and bargains accepted without due consideration.
- Fourth: Preserve the dignity of the dead.
- Even should an apparition prove hostile, one ought not immediately assume that its suffering is without cause.
- Fifth: Remain mindful of the living.
- When fear spreads through a community, suspicion follows, and suspicion has a remarkable talent for discovering imaginary enemies. A village terrified of a ghost may commit terrible deeds long before the ghost itself has harmed anyone. I have witnessed such things. I would prefer not to witness them again.

Appendix I: A Short Collection of Rural Sayings

“When the dog barks at the empty courtyard, invite no one inside.”
“A spirit fears the rooster, but a liar fears the sunrise.”
“The dead remember debts longer than the living.”
“A house with laughter need not fear its shadows.”
“Do not curse the river. It remembers where you sleep.”
“The first knock is a stranger. The second is a warning. The third is a choice.”
“When the incense burns without smoke, someone unseen is listening.”
“A borrowed lantern must be returned before dawn.”
“A grave without a name is not necessarily a grave without an occupant.”
“Never fear the ghost who asks for justice as much as a man who claims to speak for it.”

Closing Remarks: The Limits of Knowledge

I began this work believing that every unexplained occurrence must eventually yield to patient observation. I remain committed to that principle. Yet I must confess that my travels have occasionally presented circumstances which resist easy explanation. In the northern mountains, I encountered an abandoned village where every household had arranged an additional place at the dinner table. In the western forests, I found a shrine containing offerings to a deity whose name no surviving record could identify. And once, while staying at an inn near the southern frontier, I awakened to discover a handwritten letter upon my bedside table. The letter was addressed to me. It contained only seven characters.

“You have forgotten what you promised.”

The handwriting was my own. I have never discovered who placed it there. Should the reader consider this an appropriate conclusion to a catalogue of spirits, I would ask that they remember that the absence of an explanation is not proof of the supernatural. But neither is confidence proof of understanding. May your hearth remain warm, your threshold remain secure, and your ancestors remain satisfied.
— Lu Wenqing, Imperial Scholar – Written in the Forty-Seventh Year of My Life